Paid Google Maps edits target U.S. auto dealers

Assessment date: 1 October 2026 | Confidence: Moderate-High

KEY JUDGMENT

A long-standing customer on Advego, a Russian-language freelance marketplace, using the alias arsintiya commissioned at least ten paid Google Maps edits targeting U.S. automotive businesses between March and September 2026.[1] All observed tasks used the same acceptance-gated template.[1] At assessment, four of the ten identified targets displayed at least one requested contact value on Google, including two that displayed both the requested phone number and replacement domain.[4][5] In all six cases where a replacement domain could be dated, it was registered before the corresponding task.[7] Two sets of replacement contacts also appear in public victim reports alleging substantial wire-transfer losses.[8][9] The pattern is consistent with paid Google edits being used to redirect prospective customers toward contact infrastructure prepared in advance.

FINDINGS

1. Standardized workflow. Observed tasks followed a highly consistent template apart from the target and supplied phone/domain: workers used 'Suggest an edit', had to verify an 'Accepted' change, abandon pending/rejected edits, and not leave reviews or ratings.[1]

2. Requested edits were visible on four of ten targets. At assessment, four of the ten targeted Google Business listings displayed at least one contact value specified in the paid tasks. Cotroneo Auto Group and Beaver Valley Auto Sales displayed both the requested phone number and replacement domain; Gary's Auto Sales and Prestige Imports Auto Sales displayed the requested phone number. Website changes were not always bundled with phone changes: for some targets they appeared in the same task, while for others they were commissioned separately. Cotroneo provides a clear example in which both requested contact values were visible on Google at assessment.[2][3][4]

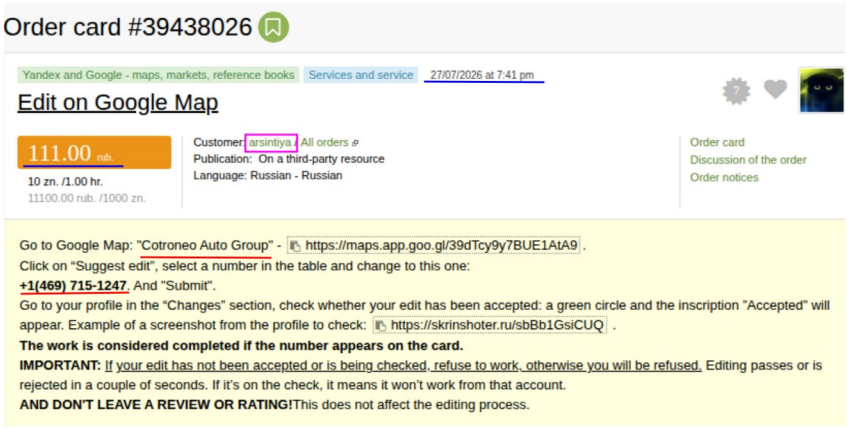


Figure 1. Current Advego order #39438026 for Cotroneo Auto Group; screenshot auto-translated from Russian.

3. Replacement infrastructure was prepared before the Google-edit stage. In all six cases where a replacement domain could be dated, the domain was registered before the corresponding paid task.[7] D&M provides a clear example: `dnmautosalesus.com` and `(469) 890-1372` were already in use before the 29 September task instructed workers to place that number on Google.[1][6]

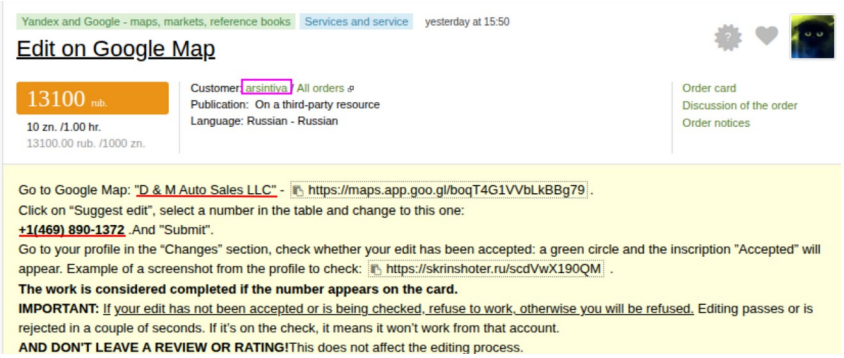


Figure 2. D&M task requesting the replacement number (469) 890-1372; screenshot auto-translated from Russian.

4. Replacement contacts also appear in victim reports. A Reddit report dated 29 August 2026 alleges an approximately $55,000 wire-transfer loss involving Cotroneo's replacement domain and phone number, after those identifiers had been introduced in the July task.[2][3][8] A separate Dealer Scam Record complaint dated 28 August 2026 alleges a $57,150 wire-transfer loss involving D&M's replacement domain and number. The complaint predates the 29 September Google-edit task, placing the same identifiers in use before that task.[1][5][9]

ANALYST ACTION: Search the identified targets and pivots across task records, complaints, Google Business history, passive DNS and payment data for additional targets and common operational or financial links.

IDENTIFIED TARGETS: Lucky Auto Sales; Live Oak Equipment; Gary's Auto Sales; L&J Motors Inc.; Denni's Auto Sales; Prestige Imports Auto Sales; Cotroneo Auto Group; Wix Auto Finance; Beaver Valley Auto Sales; D&M Auto Sales LLC.

INVESTIGATIVE PIVOTS: arsintiya; cotroneoautogroupus.com; dnmautosalesus.com; beavervalleyautosales.com; wix-autofinance.com; l-j-motorsusa.com; dennisauto-classics.com; +1 318-209-7736; +1 830-455-0377; +1 743-203-0762; +1 785-727-1371; +1 217-564-5211; +1 469-715-1247; +1 281-937-2219; +1 724-412-7403; +1 469-890-1372.

LIMITATION: The evidence does not establish that arsintiya operates the replacement infrastructure or receives victim funds; current Google matches do not prove which specific worker caused a change.

Sources: [1] Analyst screenshots of Advego tasks/profile, collected Sep-Oct 2026. [2] Analyst screenshot of Advego order #39438026 (Cotroneo Auto Group), captured 1 Oct 2026. [3] Alot.pro mirror of Advego order #39438026, preserving the Cotroneo website-addition instruction, captured 1 Oct 2026. [4] Google Business listing for Cotroneo Auto Group, checked 1 Oct 2026.[5] Remaining nine identified Google Business listings, checked 30 Sep–1 Oct 2026. [6] `dnmautosalesus.com`, checked 1 Oct 2026. [7] WHOIS/RDAP records for six replacement domains, accessed 1 Oct 2026. [8] Reddit victim report concerning Cotroneo Auto Group, dated 29 Aug 2026. [9] Dealer Scam Record complaint concerning D&M Auto Sales, dated 28 Aug 2026.